

Burners — Examples of Play

Mechanics-only run-throughs of the engine (Fuel pools, Defend, soak-on-the-way-in, negative-HP wounds). No narration — just procedure, rolls, and the gauge. See [[Burners Adventure Game]].

Example 1 — The Rat-Cellars (a crawl)

Job: clear the Rat-Cellars under Varn's granary; recover the strongbox. **Base Heat 6** (working ground). Torches burn 6 turns. Wandering check every 2nd turn, 1-in-6 (OSE procedure, unchanged).

Crew (all character level 1 — one Approach point, four Traits, HP = 1d6 rolled):

Burner	Approach	HP	Held	Fuel on the Initiative roll
Kragg	Sword 1 (Veteran)	4	war-axe (3 slots, 2-handed, enchanted), gambeson (AC 2)	4 empty + 3 axe + 1 level = 8
Sefa	Craft 1 (Journeyman)	3	leather (AC 1); silvered knife (1 slot) once looted	4 empty + 1 knife + 1 level = 6
Brand	Heart 1 (Boss)	5	sword (2), leather (AC 1)	4 empty + 2 sword + 1 level = 7
Ilsa	Sorcerie 1 (Sorcerer)	3	spear (3 physical); 5 Arcana (hand size 5 — <i>Adhere</i> ready among them); wand drip in Arcana; leather (AC 1)	5 Arcana + 3 spear + 1 level = 9 (no empty physical)

Reminder — out of combat: 2d6 + Approach vs Cost. Hostile magic: Fuel Defend vs cast total (see [[Burners Principles#Granular defense, not binary save]]).

Exploration

Turn 1 — Entry stair.

- Sefa scouts (Craft): Pay @ Heat 6 → 2d6+1 = **8** ✓. Clear, no cost.
- Torch 1/6.

Turn 2 — Cellar 1, flooded. A slick beam (balance — Defend, Craft).

- Cross, 2d6 + Craft vs Heat 6 each:
 - Kragg 2d6 = **7** ✓ · Sefa 2d6+1 = **9** ✓ · Ilsa 2d6 = **10** ✓ · Brand 2d6 = **5**, short → slips, splash and noise → **Heat 7**.
- Wandering check: d6 = **4**. Nothing.

Turn 3 — Stuck door (heavy, swollen — a hard feat, Sword vs 9).

- Kragg heaves: $2d6+1 = 8$, short → holds, time burns.
- Second try: $2d6+1 = 10$ ✓ — it grinds open.
- Torch 3/6.

Turn 4 — Cellar 2. Covered pit (trap: flat Damage 2, no roll — detect or eat).

- Sefa checks for traps (Craft): Pay @ 7 → $2d6+1 = 6$, short 1 → **Heat 8**. Pit *not* spotted.
- Marching order puts Brand on it. It springs, no telegraph, no Fuel up out of combat: Damage 2 – Brand's AC 1 (soaks on the way in) = **1 to HP**. Brand 5 → 4.
- Wandering check: $d6 = 1$ — encounter. Cellar denizens, hostile by writ: **4 grave-rats** (HD 1, 5 HP each, bite $d6 \rightarrow 2$ slots).

Combat 1 — Grave-rats (4). Heat 8

Rolling Initiative. Crew roll their Fuel (above). The rat pack rolls one pool — 4 (a die per HD) + 2 (best bite) + 8 (Heat) = **14 dice** — and, ganging like a Veteran of many levels, makes one attack per rat (each its own 1-die blow, each defended separately). Initiative is the count of 3s and 4s; Kragg reads highest and acts first.

Round 1.

- **Kragg** attacks: burns a 5 → rat 1 (5 HP) reaches 0: **Cracked!** He burns a 6 to strike a **Spark**, then Fuels it with a 2 for a second attack → the finishing blow drops rat 1.
- **Brand** attacks: burns a 5 → rat 2 is **Cracked!** (no Fuel refill from here).
- **Ilsa** (spear) attacks: burns a 4 → the Cracked rat drops.
- **Rats** act: rats 3 and 4 bite Sefa. She Defends the first 3 with a 4. Against the second 4, leather soaks 1 first; she burns a 3 to cut the rest. Zeroed.

Round 2.

- **Kragg** cracks rat 3 with one blow and finishes it with his second. **Brand** cracks rat 4; **Ilsa** finishes it. Threat overcome → **vent 2** → **Heat 6**.

Note: each 5-HP rat took one blow to Crack and another to finish. A swarm's teeth are its count of attacks, not any one blow — and a Burner's armor soaks each blow separately, so numbers grind rather than spike.

Turn 5 — rest of Cellar 2.

- Loot niche: 120 gp, a **silvered knife** (1 slot). Sefa takes the knife.
- Torch 5/6; fresh torch lit.

Turn 6 — Cellar 3, the strongroom door. Masterwork lock (thief skill vs difficulty 10).

- Sefa (Craft, tools): Deal → $2d6+1 = 9$. Holds; time cost → **Heat 7**.
- Sefa again: $2d6+1 = 12$ ✓. Open.
- Wandering check: $d6 = 6$. Nothing.

Combat 2 — The Cellarer (a wight). Heat 7 → 9

Buried armed: **grave-sword** (2 slots) and a **grave-byrnies** (old chain — loot for a Burner, not AC on the block). HD 3 → **15 HP**. **Resistance 5 vs mundane arms** — grave-cold flesh and the mail as one wall — with silver the named weakness (it ignores the Resistance). The Referee announces it rising from its bier: **+2 Heat** → **9**.

Rolling Initiative. The wight's pool is **14 dice** — 3 (HD) + 2 (sword) + 9 (Heat) — the hot scene fighting back hard. It reads six 3s/4s: **Initiative 6, first.** As a named foe it takes the full Wound rules and strikes twice.

Round 1.

- **Wight**, two grave-sword blows:
 - → **Brand**: 3 dice (6,5,4 = 15). Brand's leather soaks 1 first → 14. He has not meleed this round → one die: burns a 6 → **8 to HP**. Brand 5 → **-3: a Wound** (severity 3). Location 1d6=2, **torso, winded** — loses a Fuel die. **Shock Check: 2d6 + Sword (0) = 8 vs severity 3** ✓ — keeps his feet. (*Brand Fuel 7→5.*)
 - → **Ilsa**: 2 dice (5,5 = 10). Her leather soaks 1 first → 9. She has not meleed → one die: burns a 4 → **5 to HP**. Ilsa HP 3 → **-2: a Wound** (severity 2). Location 1d6=4, an **arm** — the spear-arm hangs useless until she reaches full HP. **Shock Check: 2d6 + Sword (0) = 6 vs severity 2** ✓ — she keeps her feet, shaken, one-armed. (*Fuel 8→7.*)
 - (*Wight burned 5 dice attacking; 9 left.*)
- **Kragg** attacks the wight (Veteran, two blows; 2-handed axe, 4 slots → two dice a blow) — having meleed, he Defends without limit for the rest of this round:
 - Blow A: 6,5,4 = 15. Resistance 5 leaves 10. Wight has already meleed this round, so Defends freely: burns a 6 → **4**. Wight **15** → **11**.
 - Blow B: 5,4 = 9. Resistance 5 leaves 4; Wight burns a 5 → **0**. Nothing. (*Wight Fuel 9→7.*)
- **Brand** attacks: sword, 1 die = 6. Resistance 5 leaves 1; Wight burns a 4 → **0**. (*Wight 7→6 dice.*)
- **Ilsa** casts *Adhere* from her hand (Thaumaturgy 1) — one Action, burn at least 1 Fuel die and roll it: a 5 → **cast total 5**. The card **taps**. The wight **Defends** (no cap vs magic), burning a 2 → **overrun 3**. The working sticks its sword-arm to the grave-byrnie — effect lane, **no HP**. Wight stays **11**. (*Ilsa Fuel 7→6; wight 6→5 dice.*)
- **Sefa**, silvered knife (ignores Resistance): 1 die = 6. Wight Defends freely (already meleed): a 2 → 6-2 = **4** through. Wight **11** → **7**.

Round 2. Roll Initiative: refill +1 die each, lock order. The wight, having burned its 14-die burst, is winded — and its sword-arm is glued to its own mail.

- **Wight** spends its Action tearing at the stuck arm: one Fuel die burned to no avail this round — no blow lands. (*Stuck is the whole point of the card.*)
- **Kragg**: 6,4 = 10. Having meleed, he will Defend freely for any further blows. Wight Defends its last die, a 2 → 8, -5 = **3**. Wight **7** → **4**. (*Even now, mundane barely tells.*)
- **Sefa** (silver): 5. Wight out of dice → no defense. Resistance bypassed → **5** through → past 0 by 1: **the killing Wound**. The Cellarer falls — steel and silver dealt the damage; the working only took its arm out of the fight.
- **Ilsa**: *Adhere* is tapped and the spear-arm is dead — she falls back and covers the door. Ready magic is what sits ready in her hand; sleep recovers up to Sorcerie Level cards.
- Threat overcome → **vent 2** → **Heat 7**.

Turn 7 — Strongbox.

- Carried out whole (2 slots; Kragg drops a torch bundle to fit it).
- Sefa checks for a second exit (Craft): Pay @ 7 → 2d6+1 = **11** ✓ — an old coal chute, out that way, skipping the flooded beam.

After

- **Downtime**: Heat cools to base; the job stayed quiet, so the town base is unchanged.
- **Take**: strongbox (Referee: 400 gp + deed papers), 120 gp, silvered knife, **the Cellarer's grave-sword** — old, fine make, a worn-off name (a Signature waiting to be read) — and its **grave-byrnie** (mail; Kragg claims it).
- **Wounds**: Ilsa sits at **-2 HP** (severity 2) with a dead arm; Brand at **-3** (severity 3) winded. After the fight, allies **help**; each makes **2d6 + Craft vs severity** (or die). Helped and passed: **1 HP per day** with

food until **full HP**, then the Wound closes. Hour Rest does nothing while Wounded. Ilsa may spend a sleep-recovery card to untap *Adhere*.

• **Torches spent: 2. Turns: 7.**

Procedure Notes

- **OSE clocks unchanged:** 10-minute turns, torch tracking, wandering checks every 2nd turn at 1-in-6.
 - **One roll out of combat:** 2d6 + Approach vs Cost. Traps — see [[Burners Principles#Pools, not fixed numbers]].
 - **Fuel is rolled on each Roll Initiative** — full pool on round 1; from round 2 on, refill one Fuel die per character level and roll those in, then lock order. **Cracked** monsters get no refill. The wight's 14-dice pool (swollen by 9 Heat) made round 1 murderous; by round 2 the refill was thin and the fight turned. A hot scene hits hardest on the first exchange.
 - **Damage is the faces of burned dice**, minus a Burner's armor AC or a monster's Resistance, then minus the defender's burned Fuel dice. A blow is one die; a weapon of 3+ slots wielded in two hands can add a second. Monsters have no AC. Monsters at **0 down to -Max HP** are **Cracked!** (no Resistance, no Fuel refill; next damaging hit finishes). **Past -Max HP** they are **Splatted!**
 - **Defense:** melee 1 die (no limit once you have meleed this round); missile 1 die (2 with Cover); magic no limit. **Block** spends one melee attack to redirect a blow onto yourself. **Cover** lets you burn 2 vs a missile; Fuel a Spark while using a melee foe as Cover to dump the shot into them.
 - **The Wound model:** see [[Burners Principles#HP is plot armor; past 0 it gets real]].
 - **Casting is the same economy:** Ilsa's *Adhere* was one Action, one Fuel die rolled for the **cast total**; the card **tapped**; the wight Defended with a die of its own and ate the **overrun** as control — sword-arm stuck, no HP lost. Hostile utility burns the same Fuel pool as steel, and lives in the effect lane. Sleep recovers up to Sorcerie Level cards.
 - **Resistance vs the named weakness:** the wight's Resistance 5 (grave-cold and the byrnie as one wall) made mundane steel almost useless, while silver ignored the Resistance (Sefa). Sorcery did not chip the Resistance at all — it took the monster's arm out of the exchange so the fighters could finish. **Sorcerers solve; fighters kill.**
 - **The monster's slot/Fuel economy cuts both ways:** the wight burned its huge pool attacking and Defending, so by Sefa's turn it could spare only a die or two. Tie up its dice — or its arm — then land the answer.
 - **Nobody died.** Shock kept them combat-effective; help after the fight bought the Craft survival checks. That is what a clean job looks like.
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Example 2 — The Gulls' Rest (a parley gone sharp)

The same crew, a week later, fencing the deed papers from the Rat-Cellars. This one starts as a social scene on Heart and turns into a fight mid-sentence — watch where the initiative roll lands.

Scene: a back table at the Gulls' Rest, evening crowd. The buyer is **Marlow**, a dockside fixer, flanked by two **bravos** and a quiet man with rings — a **sharper** (Sorcerer, Illusione). **Base Heat 4** (a quiet meet, but a crowded room and money on the table).

What's in hand matters tonight. Nobody walks into a parley holding a war-axe. Kragg's axe rides his back, Brand's sword is at his hip, Sefa's silvered knife is a holdout in her boot. Held slots only count on the Initiative roll if the thing is *in hand* when steel comes out.

The parley (Heart)

- **First meeting — Reaction roll** (Referee): 2d6 + Brand's Heart 1 = **8**. Cool but willing: Marlow will deal, at his price.

- **Brand opens** — the papers for 300 gp. That is a fair ask backed by real goods, so it simply works as an offer on the table (Step 1); no roll for whether the world listens.
- **Marlow lowballs** — 100 gp, and a smile. Brand wants the fixer's *real* ceiling — a read, and risky to press for: Pay @ Heat 4 → $2d6+1 = 9$ ✓. The Referee gives it: Marlow is fronting for Varn's rival and will pay well over 300 — but he wants the crew *cheap or gone*.
- **Brand presses** — names the rival aloud, and asks 400. A hard squeeze on a made man: Pay @ Heat 4 → $2d6+1 = 6$, short → the squeeze shows, the table hears it → **Heat 5**.
- **Sefa reads the room** (Craft): Deal @ 5 → $2d6+1 = 10$ ✓ — the bravos have shifted their stools clear of the table, and the ringed man's hands are under it. A revealed threat sets a floor: **Heat holds at 5, floor 5**.
- **Marlow leans back** — “Three hundred, then. Shake on it.” The Referee telegraphs: the sharper's lips are moving.

Steel comes out — roll initiative

The sharper casts a working at Brand. **A hostile spell is an attack: roll initiative.** He gains no free first strike for starting it — the whole room rolls with what it holds *right now*.

Side	Pool	Dice
Kragg (tankard, axe on back)	4 empty + 1 level	5
Sefa (knife in boot — a holdout)	4 empty + 1 level	5
Brand (sword at hip, not in hand)	4 empty + 1 level	5
Ilsa (5 Arcana declared; wand drip; no spear tonight)	5 Arcana + 1 level	6
Sharper (HD 1; Illusione hand; <i>Bewitch</i> ready)	1 HD + 6 Heat (enemy side, once)	7
Bravos (knives worn, ×2)	1 HD + 1 knife each	2 each

Initiative is the count of 3s and 4s. Kragg reads **3**, the sharper **2**, Ilsa **2**, Brand **1**, Sefa **1**, bravos **1** and **0**. **Kragg acts before the man whose spell started the fight.**

Round 1.

- **Kragg** (Veteran, two attacks; the axe stays sheathed — this is a tavern) burns a held 6 to strike a **Spark**, then Fuels it with 5,4 to **Man-handle** — heaves the table into the sharper. Force 9; the sharper Defends $4,2 = 6$ → bowled over, **in the dirt**, and his concentration goes with his footing — but the working is already in the air; it resolves on his turn. He spends one of his Veteran attacks to **Block** for Brand: if a blow comes for Brand, it redirects onto Kragg. (*Kragg 5→2 dice; order stays locked.*)
- **Sharper** (from the floor) finishes the cast — *Bewitch* (Illusione 1, ready in hand): burns 1 Fuel die = **5**. **Cast total 5**. The card taps. Brand may Defend — but **Ilsa is adjacent and Wards**: Sorcerie 1, she burns 1 Fuel die (a 4), cutting the cast to **1**. **Brand then Defends** with 1 die (a 3) → fully defended. No charm, no HP. (*Ilsa 6→5; Brand 5→4; sharper 7→6.*)
- **Ilsa** (her Action still unspent — Ward is not a turn): casts *Adhere* from her hand at the sharper. 1 die = **6** — cast total 6, and the 6 is a **Spark**. The card taps. The sharper, in the dirt and rattled, Defends with 2 dice: $3,2 = 5$. **Overrun 1** — his casting hand sticks to the floorboards (effect lane, **no HP**; he stays at 5). She Fuels the Spark with another die and burns it on the working itself: the Referee lets the glue catch his other wrist as well — no ready cards until he washes free. (*Ilsa 5→3; sharper 6→4.*)
- **Bravo 1** lunges at Sefa, knife out: 1 die = **4**. Sefa has not meleed this round → one die: burns a 3 → 1 through, no armor tonight → **Sefa 3 HP → 2**. (*Sefa 5→4.*)
- **Brand** rises, sword *now* in hand (drawing comes free with his Action), and swings at bravo 1: 1 die = **5** → 5 dmg, bravo 1 (5 HP) **down**. (*Brand 5→4.*)
- **Sefa** draws the holdout — **1 Fuel to pull it in a fight** — and marks bravo 2. (*Sefa 4→3.*)
- **Bravo 2** hesitates — his partner is down, the sharper is stuck to the boards. **Morale check (2d6 under Morale 7): 6** — **holds**, barely. He circles.

Round 2. Roll Initiative: refill +1 die each, count, lock order; Kragg still tops it.

- **Kragg's** refill is a 6. He burns it to strike a **Spark**, then Fuels it with 4,3 to haul the sharper up by the collar — a **Man-handle** to grapple, force 7 against a man in the dirt, pinned; the Referee rules there is no real contest. Held fast. (*Kragg 3→0.*)
- **Sharper**, ringless and in a fist: folds. “Enough — *enough.*”
- **Bravo 2** — his principal just quit: **Morale check: 10 — breaks**, and he's out the door.
- Fight over. It never rose past the floor: **Heat 5**, and the room saw the *other* table start it.

After

- **The deal:** Marlow, dusting off his coat, pays **350 gp** for the papers — the crew's read was true, and the botched charm shamed his table, which is worth 50 gp of face. Money changes hands over a righted table.
- **The take:** 350 gp, one confiscated **ring** (Wizard Drip find; no bonus cards), and a bravo's knife in the floorboards.
- **Hurts:** Sefa 2/3 HP — an hour's rest with food refills her. Nobody wounded, nobody dead, nothing burned. In a tavern that is a masterpiece of restraint.
- **Heat:** cools to the town base at downtime. The Gulls' Rest will serve them again. Marlow will not forget.

Procedure Notes

- **Social scenes:** see [[Burners Principles#Two engines]] and [[Burners Principles#Heat is scene pressure]]. Heart pays for risky reads and squeezes as Pay rolls.
- **Heat is the social gauge too.** The meet opened at 4, climbed on a botched press, and a revealed threat set a floor. When steel came out, that same number armed the enemy side — the 6 Heat dice in the sharper's pool are the scene's temperature cashing in, added once for the whole side.
- **Declaring an attack is “roll initiative” — and the declarer is not first.** The sharper's charm started the fight and Kragg still beat him to the floor. A hostile working where no fight is underway triggers initiative like a drawn blade; nobody gets a free strike for moving first in the fiction.
- **You fight with what's in hand.** Tavern pools are thin: sheathed swords and slung axes throw no dice on the Initiative roll. Ilsa's declared Arcana slots carried her share. Brand's draw came free with his Action; Sefa's holdout cost the 1 Fuel a holdout costs.
- **Ward, shown:** Ilsa cuts the cast with $\leq$ Sorcerie Level Fuel; Brand then Defends the remainder. Control never lands partially on a clean stop.
- **Control is effect-only:** see [[Burners Principles#Harm and effect are separate lanes]]. Had the charm landed, Brand loses no HP — the crew attacks the reason (concentration, hand, skin).
- **Morale as written (2d6 vs the score):** the bravos were never going to die for Marlow's face. One blow and one bad round asked the question twice, and the second answer was the door.